concerns, for instance, are already being addressed to avoid any delay in the programme's implementation. The process could be reversed at any time, and this would address the concerns of the activists, remarks Ratan.

Exuding enormous confidence and happiness at the prospects of his anti-malarial project becoming a success, he told me that: 'It is just going into the field testing. There could be no reason why it would not be successful.' When the programme is implemented, India would stand to significantly benefit, as the country has amongst the highest incidence of malaria in the world with nearly 10 million cases reported in 2017 alone. Though of late, the incidence of the disease has reduced somewhat, the government concluded that, 'Malaria is a public health problem in several parts of the country' especially as 'about 95% population in the country resides in malaria endemic areas'.

By 2021, there was considerable progress in the implementation of this vision when researchers from TIGS and Institute of Bioinformatics and Applied Biotechnology (IBAB) an autonomous institute at Bengaluru, 'unveiled the detailed genome of the malaria mosquito vector', revealing the discovery of 'thousands of new genes vital for the development of genetic control strategies of disease transmission'.

The next year, biologists at the University of San Diego, in collaboration with TIGS, in a research paper funded by Tata Trusts, announced the development of a technology to reverse 'insecticide resistance'. Using this technology, Dr Ethan Bier, professor at the university and author of the paper, revealed that they had developed a genetic editing tool to 'replace an insecticide-resistant gene in fruit files'. The same technology could be employed to increase the 'proportion of a naturally occurring genetic variant in mosquitoes that renders them refractory to transmission or malarial parasites'. When this technology moves from the lab to the ground, it would bring telling benefit to millions of Indians and aid in India's 'plan to eliminate Malaria by 2030', as Ratan had envisioned.

But eradicating malaria is only the tip of the iceberg of Ratan's vision: it is a precursor to finding a solution to much larger and more debilitating ailments. TIGS could soon be working on 'something which many doctors or scientists have been dreaming about, have a vaccine for cancer. It would work exactly the same way', he explains. With the zeal of a missionary, he adds, 'So when we sit in a meeting and there [is] the possibility of that happening, it spurs me on to see if I can support this and play a role in that